



THE TECH EDGE

- **Security agencies are now using advanced technologies for surveillance and analysing Naxal activities**
- **Drones, satellite imaging and Artificial Intelligence-based data analysis employed**
- **Through location tracking, cell-phone triangulation, advanced call logging and social media analysis, a close watch is being kept on the movements of Naxal cadres**



Prior to their introduction six years ago, security camps were set up mainly on the highways near Naxal-infested areas and forces would conduct linear attacks. They would have to walk or trek as much as 30 km a day from their camps to launch operations against the Naxals, making them vulnerable to both exhaustion and easy ambushes. Now the FOBs are in the thick of jungles, close to the Naxal hideouts, and form a tight security grid 5 km from each other. In case of an attack on one camp, reinforcements are at hand and can be called upon if needed.

Most of the combat troops are trained in guerrilla warfare at the sprawling centre of the fearsome Commando Battalion for Resolute Action (CoBRA) in Jagdalpur, once the capital of undivided Bastar, which is the size of Kerala and spans seven thickly forested districts in Chhattisgarh. Amit Choudhary, the chiselled and fit commandant of the 201 Cobra Battalion, says, "We are fighting a battle-hardened adversary who belongs to the area, is well-versed with the terrain, highly mobile in the jungles and uses the art of deception and patience to stealthily attack us using IEDs or ambushes. They need to succeed only once to sustain the fervour, while we must score every day." The Cobras impart training to both central and state forces in three broad areas: to ensure their own safety against booby traps and ambush strategies, to ensure pinpoint accuracy while firing their weapons and to withstand the stress—physical and mental—that the hostile jungle terrain and their cunning adversary can trigger.

Currently, there are 182 security FOBs in the Bastar region, with the pace of establishing them only intensifying. Earlier, an average of 15 camps were set up annually,